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Migrant children transitioning from kindergarten to primary school in Germany: educators' and parents' views of school transition activities

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ABSTRACT

The transition to school can be a challenge for migrant children. How educators and parents of migrant children perceive transition activities still needs to be better understood. In this mixed-methods study, we examined how transition activities were perceived by 36 educators and 116 parents of migrant children across Germany during the transition from kindergarten to primary school. Educators' views of transition activities were investigated using a survey and focus group discussions before the transition. Parents' views were evaluated using a survey after the transition. Results revealed that specific transition activities, namely communication and collaboration among educators and parents, took place and were perceived as important, but specific challenges made their implementation difficult. School policies that address the transition to school of migrant children should focus on the views of migrant families and educators who work with them and future research should seek to understand these views further.

KEYWORDS

Transition; school; migration; educators; parents

Introduction and background

Children's transition to primary school is an important life event with potential lifelong consequences, such as for later academic achievement (Alatalo, Meier, and Frank 2016; Dockett and Perry 2007; Fabian and Dunlop 2007; Huser, Dockett, and Perry 2016; Rimm-Kaufman, Pianta, and Cox 2000; Symonds 2015). This study focuses on the transition from kindergarten to primary school in Germany. In Germany, kindergarten includes all formal pre-primary education settings. First grade is the entry-level grade in primary schools. This is equivalent to pre-school in the United States and some parts of Australia. More specifically, we focus on how educators and parents of migrant children in Germany perceive transition activities. In this manuscript, the term migrant refers to all persons who move to Germany from abroad, primarily to

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improve their living conditions. The term transition is understood as a process whereby a person adapts to a new environment following a significant change (Huser, Dockett, and Perry 2016; OECD 2006; Walther, Stauber, and Settersten Jr 2022). The school transition specifically is understood as the process of movement from one phase or context of education to another (Broström 2002; Fabian and Dunlop 2007; Yeboah 2002).

While many children seamlessly manage the transition to school, entering a new educational setting can cause some children to experience stress and even develop anxiety (Leblond et al. 2023). This is due to the significant changes resulting from the transition and the need to adjust to new routines, rules, norms, expectations, and new environments in which new relationships with peers and adults are formed (Dockett and Perry 2007; Dunlop and Fabian 2007; Huser, Dockett, and Perry 2016; Skouteris, Watson, and Lum 2012). Moreover, children's experience of the transition to the first year of schooling can have long-term implications for their adaptation to school in general and future outcomes such as academic achievement and social competences (Alexander, Entwisle, and Horsey 1997; Belsky and MacKinnon 1994; Dumclaus et al. 2014; Margetts 2009; Ramey and Ramey 2004). Negative school transition experiences, such as experiencing high levels of stress, are predictive of future academic underachievement (Dumclaus et al. 2014). Thus, supporting all children in their transition to school is crucial. Past research suggests that educators play an essential role in children's school transitions and can potentially influence transition outcomes (Ackesjö 2013; Dockett 2010; Dockett and Perry 2007). For instance, caring student-educator relationships can enhance children's feelings of self-worth and their overall resilience (Fabian and Dunlop 2007). That is why educators need to be aware of the challenges children encounter during these life events (Balduzzi et al. 2019; Dumclaus et al. 2014). In sum, the different levels of support required by children transitioning to school should be recognized by schools and educators, whose role is to facilitate the transition experience of all children.

Although there is substantive research on the transition to formal schooling among native children, namely, children whose parents were born in the country where they live, studies investigating the school transition of migrant children are scarce. Research by Picchio and Mayer (2019) examining the experience of 32 migrant children transitioning within early childhood education and care settings using video observation found that the transition process is especially difficult for them as they experience multiple discontinuities compared to native children. They emphasize the importance of educators' behavioral approaches to working with migrant children, such as being welcoming and attentive to their needs during the transition process so that they can adjust (Picchio and Mayer 2019). In addition, Peleman, Vandenbroeck, and Van Avermaet (2019) also used video observation methods to analyze the experiences of children from migrant backgrounds (exact definition not provided), as reported by their parents, in the transition to preschool in the Flemish community of Belgium. They found that preschools tend to work assuming that nearly every child has attended preschool, speaks Dutch, can manage interactions with peers, and is familiar with the 'implicit curriculum' under which preschool institutions operate (e.g. timetables, rules, and values). Their results are consistent with other research showing that children whose families know how to navigate the educational system have more successful transitions, namely have positive educational experiences of the transition that lead to better social and academic outcomes (Cook, Coley, and Zimmermann 2019), than children who are less familiar

with the school system. The lack of conclusive research, especially using mixed methods, suggests that more needs to be done to understand views of school transitions, focusing on migrant children, their educators, and their parents, to address this knowledge gap and achieve equitable and quality education. The present study investigated the following research question: What are the views of educators and parents on the transition activities of migrant children who are transitioning from kindergarten to primary school? To answer this question, this study aimed to investigate educators' and migrant parents' views of school transition activities using quantitative surveys and qualitative focus group methods. The distal goal was to inform early childhood education policy and practice in Germany.

Transition activities based on Rimm-Kaufman and Pianta's (2000) ecological and dynamic model of transitions

Educators can support children by implementing transition activities to facilitate their school transition experience (LoCasale-Crouch et al. 2008). Transition activities comprise all activities and practices geared toward children's transition to a different school (or school level) that occur before, during, and after the transition and involve the school, child, and family (Bohan-Baker and Little 2002; Rimm-Kaufman and Pianta 2000). One model that attempts to explain the complexity of the transition process and the importance of transition activities is Rimm-Kaufman and Pianta's (2000) ecological and dynamic model of transitions. Rimm-Kaufman and Pianta's (2000) model emphasizes the importance of various actors, namely children, parents, educators, school staff, peers and the wider community, and how their roles are interconnected and interdependent throughout the transition process. It is based on Bronfenbrenner and Morris's (1998) bioecological model of human development, which emphasizes the dynamic interaction between a child's development and that child's environment. However, it further argues that transition activities, such as the sharing of information between all parties involved, organizing visits for children to the new school, arranging meetings with the new educators and involving parents, such as by organizing home visits, are essential to facilitate collaboration between schools and families for the benefit of the child (Pianta and Kraft-Sayre 2003).

More importantly, proactively engaging in these transition activities enhances the linkages between actors involved in the transition, namely children, parents and educators, contributing to a smoother transition experience for the child (Pianta et al. 1999). For example, Schulting, Malone, and Dodge (2005) found in a sample of 2,991 teachers and 17,212 native children transitioning from preschool to kindergarten in the USA that the number of transition activities kindergarten teachers implemented, assessed using a self-report survey, was a significant predictor of children's academic achievement scores at the end of the school year. Likewise, in their study of 722 native children and their pre-kindergarten teachers in the USA, LoCasale-Crouch et al. (2008) found a positive association between the number of transition activities carried out with them in pre-kindergarten, assessed using a self-report survey of those activities that were implemented and those they planned to implement, and children's social competencies rated by their teachers in their new school. Research about specific transition activities, such as communications and exchanges of information between educational institutions,

further highlights their benefits. An online survey study of 61 preschool educators and 52 school educators in Australia by Hopps (2014) found that all participants considered communication between both institutions valuable and worthwhile for the transition experience of children and families, but not occurring sufficiently often. Another survey study of 932 Norwegian children and their teachers by Cook, Dearing, and Zachrisson (2017) found information sharing, namely whether the new school had contact with the child's previous school and received information specifically about the child, between preschools and primary schools to be positively associated with communication skills, academic skills, and social skills later on in the school year.

Studies also suggest that educators and parents may also be affected by their child's transition to school because, for instance, they have to form new relationships with the new school staff (Rimm-Kaufman and Pianta 2000). Educators and parents are also motivated to implement and take part in transition activities. In an interview and self-report survey study in the USA by La Paro, Kraft-Sayre, and Pianta (2003), 36 preschool teachers and 83 parents rated different transition activities on a scale from 'not helpful', 'somewhat helpful' to 'very helpful'. They almost unanimously rated all activities as 'somewhat helpful' or 'very helpful', despite barriers such as insufficient time to carry out activities because of work schedules. Furthermore, collaboration between schools and parents during the transition has improved children's attitudes toward school, attendance, grades, and graduation rates (Dearing, Kreider, and Weiss 2008; Schulting, Malone, and Dodge 2005). That is why it is also essential to consider parents' perspectives on transition activities.

Despite these promising findings, effective and practical transition activities, specifically ones tailored to the needs of migrant children and their families, still need to be better understood. This is important as, according to Rimm-Kaufman and Pianta's (2000) model, several factors associated with the home, school, language, culture, and characteristics of migrant children could contribute to their school transition experiences (Galindo and Sheldon 2012).

The present study

The available research suggests that transition activities implemented in schools are essential for children's school transitions and their families, especially for those unfamiliar with the country's education system and language. This study sought to contribute to research on early childhood education in Europe by exploring the views of educators and parents of migrant children on transition activities in Germany. This country has been experiencing a significant influx of migrants since 2015 (UNHCR 2023), especially from Syria, Turkey, and Ukraine (Statistisches Bundesamt 2024b). Almost a third were children and young people under the age of 18 years (Statistisches Bundesamt 2024b), indicating that a substantial proportion are involved in the German educational system. However, while German schools are legally required to admit children from migrant backgrounds, the migrant education integration policy differs across German federations, such as on whether language courses are provided (Korntheuer and Damm 2020). Moreover, newly arrived children entering the educational system in Germany often face significant challenges, such as the language barrier, which impedes parental involvement and adds stress due to integrating into a new system

(Georgi 2024; Koehler and Schneider 2019; Passaretta and Skopek 2021). Hence, there is a need to better understand their experiences and views on transition activities.

That is why, for the present study, a survey and focus groups were conducted with educators before the school transition to gain in-depth insights into educators' views of transition activities. Parents' views of transition activities after their child transitioned to primary school were also assessed. The results of the educator survey, educator focus groups, and parent survey were then triangulated to determine areas of convergence and divergence. More specifically, quantitative and qualitative methods were used to understand perspectives on transition activities, capture key actors' voices and potentially capture complex perspectives that cannot be captured by either method alone. This way, using mixed methods and different informants, results were expected to provide a broad and nuanced understanding of perceptions of transition activities (Creswell and Creswell 2017). Based on past research (Cook, Dearing, and Zachrisson 2017; La Paro, Kraft-Sayre, and Pianta 2003), it was expected that educators and parents of migrant children would ultimately value transition activities and express that more of these should be carried out, especially the desire for more communication between educational institutions and parents.

Method

Study context, design and participants

The data used for the present study were part of a larger project investigating the efficacy of a program called *Vor-Sprung* over different locations throughout Germany. *Vor-Sprung* is a program developed by the International Rescue Committee (IRC) Germany, designed to provide kindergarten and primary school educators with resources to support children from migrant families to ensure a safe and successful transition. The program comprises different workshops and networking activities. For example, the workshops address emotion regulation, feelings of self-esteem, the role of toxic stress and resilience for children, and the importance of maintaining a stable environment with active collaboration between kindergarten and primary school educators (International Rescue Committee 2021). Because educators' and parents' perceptions of transition activities were central to this study, these were investigated exclusively. A more detailed description of this program and its effects is addressed in other literature (International Rescue Committee 2021). We sought to collect valuable data on school transition views parallel to the implementation of *Vor-Sprung* to provide initial insight into this important topic.

Study participants were educators and newly migrated Arab parents from different parts of Germany where *Vor-Sprung* was implemented: Cottbus in the state of Brandenburg, Magdeburg in the state of Saxony-Anhalt, Salzgitter in the state of Lower Saxony, and various locations in the state of Mecklenburg-Vorpommern. All data for this study were collected between February 2021 and January 2022. The survey sample included 36 educators. Descriptive statistics of the educators who took part in the educator survey can be found in Table 1.

The focus group sample included 33 educators who had participated in one of nine focus groups before the school transition. Participant educators included kindergarten

Table 1. Descriptive statistics of the educator survey sample ($n = 36$).

Age (years)	$M = 40.0$	$SD = 9.2$
Work experience (years)	$M = 14.6$	$SD = 10.7$
Gender		
Female	$n = 32$	
Male	$n = 4$	
Educational setting		
Kindergarten	$n = 22$	
Primary school	$n = 11$	

and school teachers, school leaders, and social workers. Details of the focus group participants can be found in [Table 2](#).

For the parent survey, 116 newly migrated Arab parents (female: $n = 55$; male: $n = 61$; age: $M = 38.49$ years; $SD = 10.96$) participated after the school transition. We could not determine when and why the parents came to Germany. Only parents whose children were transitioning from kindergarten to school (rather than straight from home to school without having attended kindergarten) were invited to participate.

Procedure

Because the sample for this study included, in part, a vulnerable population, specific ethical procedures were followed to guarantee the well-being of participants (Bertram et al. 2025). Efforts made to respect ethical codes will be described in the following section.

Ethical approval was obtained by the research team from the ethics review committee of the Department of Education and Psychology at the Freie Universität Berlin, Germany. The IRC Germany supported recruiting educators to participate in the program. The research team invited primary school teachers, kindergarten and school social workers, and kindergarten teachers by email, letter, or phone call to the school to complete a survey online or in pen-and-paper form between February 2021 and December 2021 and, for the educators only, to participate in focus groups. The focus groups occurred directly after the workshop program sessions, either online or in person. All participants were given a letter of consent, which they were asked to sign and return, for participation in the survey and again when participating in the focus groups. The letter provided information about the research project and informed participants of their rights. It indicated that their participation would be confidential and that they could withdraw from the study at any time without consequences. As a thank you for their participation, educators were provided with information material on working with children from migrant families provided by the IRC.

Table 2. Descriptive statistics of the educator focus group sample ($n = 33$).

Gender	
Female	$n = 27$
Male	$n = 6$
Educational setting	
Kindergarten	$n = 22$
Primary school	$n = 11$

Parents were invited to complete a survey after the school transition between November 2021 and January 2022. This was done by Arabic-speaking research team members respectfully approaching families at the school when parents came to pick up their children, as they knew the families personally, presenting the research project and inviting them to participate in the survey. As per the research objectives of the original *Vor-Sprung* study, recruitment had to focus specifically on migrant families. In line with ethics guidelines (Bertram et al. 2025), parents were informed of their rights, were not pressured to participate, were provided with written consent, and were invited to reach out to the research team in case of any questions or concerns in a culturally sensitive manner. Participants' rights were respected at all times, and all measures were employed to respect them as individuals and avoid objectification. For example, the Arabic-speaking research team members made sure to take sufficient time to explain the study to interested parents, explain the data collection procedure to them, and respected families' wishes not to participate in the investigation in case they expressed not wanting to. Snowball sampling was also used to recruit parents. Parents were asked if they knew other parents who would be interested in participating. The members of the research team helped them to fill out the survey on-site, or parents filled out the survey at home in their own time, depending on their preferences, and they provided parents with contact information in case any questions arose after completion of the survey. Parents were provided only technical support when completing the survey, such as being helped to navigate the online format of the survey, but were not helped with answering the questions themselves. Although a questionnaire was carried out with parents rather than interviews or focus groups, the members of the research team sought to create an atmosphere of trust in which parents felt empowered to express themselves and felt they were listened to.

No identifying information was collected to ensure confidentiality. All data was kept on secure servers, which only the investigators could access, and was not distributed to other parties. In return for participation, participant parents received a gift voucher worth 15 Euros. While offering incentives could be seen as problematic, careful consideration was made about providing incentives, and this voucher was merely meant to compensate participants for their time (Bertram et al. 2025). All participants were offered access to a summary of the findings upon completion of the research. All procedures followed the EU General Data Protection Regulation codified by German federal law.

Measures

Educator survey

The Transition Activity Scale (TAS) (Kraft-Sayre and Pianta 1999) measured educators' views of transition activities. It consists of 10 items (e.g. 'Informing the child's family in writing about the transition process') for which participants indicate the frequencies with which these were implemented during the transition process (1 = *never* to 4 = *very often*) and whether these activities are seen as important (1 = *not important* to 4 = *very important*). The TAS was part of a larger test battery, consisting of various data collection tools, which took participants 34 minutes to complete on average. The TAS was translated into German and then back-translated into English to check for accuracy.

Educator focus groups

After participating in the Vor-Sprung workshop, educators were asked to participate in focus group discussions, which ranged in size between two and seven educators. They were asked about challenges migrant children face before the school transition and how educators can support them, namely, specific activities or competencies.

Parent survey

Parents completed an adapted version of the ‘Behavioral Involvement in Transition’ subsection of the Family Experiences and Involvement in Transition (FEIT) survey (McIntyre et al. 2007). They were asked to rate 13 transition activities (such as ‘An open house at my child’s future school’) on a three-point scale (1 = *Yes, happened*, 2 = *Did not happen, but I wish it had*, and 3 = *Did not happen, not needed either*). The FEIT was translated into German and Arabic. The FEIT was part of a larger test battery, consisting of various data collection tools, which took participants around 10 minutes to complete on average.

Data analysis

Descriptive statistics were calculated for TAS and FEIT scores for the survey data. The focus group data were analyzed using qualitative content analysis (Mayring and Fenzl 2019). This method is based on systematic text analysis, using an approach of systematic coding and categorizing, which allows for the quantification of data by determining the frequency of codes (Mayring and Fenzl 2019). All steps of coding and data analysis were performed in MAXQDA 2022. Responses were categorized into units of meaning, following the content analysis procedures (Mayring and Fenzl 2019).

Results

Educators’ perceptions of transition activities

Educators reported a relatively low frequency of transition activities ($M = 2.07$; $SD = 0.88$), although they perceived them as important ($M = 3.07$; $SD = 0.75$). The ratings are presented in Table 3. The items in the table are presented in order of frequency with which they were reported being implemented, with the most frequently rated items presented first.

The activities with the highest reported implementation frequency and importance were ‘Within the work with parents’ (Frequency: $M = 2.54$; Importance: $M = 3.44$), ‘Talking about the transition with the children’ (Frequency: $M = 2.51$; Importance: $M = 3.42$), ‘Working with the team that planned the children’s transition’ (Frequency: $M = 2.46$; Importance: $M = 3.25$) and ‘Forwarding information to the parents about school orientation’ (Frequency: $M = 2.43$; Importance: $M = 2.94$). The activities with the lowest reported implementation frequency and importance were ‘Forwarding information to the child about school orientation’ (Frequency: $M = 2.03$; Importance: $M = 2.94$) and ‘Initiating introductions with the school staff of other institutions’ (Frequency: $M = 1.66$; Importance: $M = 2.94$). On average, all activities were rated lower in implementation frequency than perceived importance. The two activities, which were rated lowest in

Table 3. Educator Ratings on the Transition to Kindergarten Activities Questionnaire (TAS; Kraft-Sayre & Pianta, 1999)

	Frequency		Perceived importance	
	<i>M</i>	<i>SD</i>	<i>M</i>	<i>SD</i>
Within the work with parents	2.54	0.85	3.44	0.61
Talking about the transition with the children	2.51	0.89	3.42	0.65
Working with the team that planned the child's transition	2.46	0.98	3.25	0.69
Forwarding information to the parents about school orientation	2.43	1.04	3.25	0.87
Written information for the children's families about the transition process	2.31	1.05	3.11	0.83
Telephone conversations with staff of other institutions	2.14	0.97	3.08	0.77
Forwarding information to the child about school orientation	2.03	0.90	2.94	0.80
Initiating introductions with the school staff of other institutions	1.66	0.73	2.94	0.76
Showing the children their classroom	1.45	0.91	3.19	0.69
Organizing home visits of the children's families	1.14	0.43	2.11	0.80

Note: Frequency scale: 1 = never; 4 = very often; Perceived importance scale: 1 = not important; 4 = very important

frequency of implementation but highest in importance, were 'Showing the children their classroom' (Frequency: $M = 1.45$; Importance: $M = 3.19$) and 'Initiating introductions with the school staff of other institutions' (Frequency: $M = 1.66$; Importance: $M = 2.94$). These results demonstrate that educators implemented transition activities and considered specific means of communication and collaboration more important than others.

In the focus groups, educators were asked about challenges migrant children face before the school transition and how educators can support them, namely, specific activities or competencies. The themes identified in the focus groups are presented in Table 4.

All nine focus groups mentioned the need for communication and exchanges across the educational institutions involved in the school transition process ($n = 9$; 100%), for example, to exchange information about the child in question ($n = 5$; 55.6%):

With good cooperation between the preschool and also with the parents, these [problems] could have been averted in good time if there was good cooperation between the institutions. (Focus group 7)

They reported this as an essential activity, especially for the primary school to receive information about the child, such as any migration experiences ($n = 4$; 44%), but also that these activities require much time ($n = 7$; 77.8%).

All nine focus groups also discussed the importance of communication and collaboration with parents ($n = 9$; 100%), but that this was seen as difficult ($n = 4$; 44%) despite initiatives to reach out to them ($n = 7$; 77.8%):

Table 4. Themes identified in the analysis of the nine focus groups ($n = 33$ participants).

- Need for activities with other institutions (9)
 - Allowing time for this communication (7)
 - Information exchange between schools about the child, such as about experience of displacement and/or migration (4)
- Communications with parents (9)
 - Importance of communication/collaboration (9)
 - Teacher initiatives to reach parents (7)
 - Difficulty reaching parents (3)
- Importance of activities with children (8)
 - Having an introduction day (6)
 - Give children the opportunity to build attachment/familiarity with new school (5)

Note: Numbers in brackets indicate the number of focus groups that mentioned the specific theme.

I think to invite parents for a chat, with an interpreter, if necessary, and perhaps clarify any questions, to make the transition transparent. (Focus group 4)

Finally, eight of the nine focus groups ($n = 8$; 88.9%) also mentioned activities for children, such as having an introduction day, namely a day before the first day of school where children get to visit their new school ($n = 6$; 66.7%) and get to know their teachers ($n = 4$; 44%), also as necessary for the school transition process.

And there are schools that do a preschool event in their school, so the groups come to the school and get to know a few teachers. You could, among other things, do a scavenger hunt through the school. Or you could simply walk through all the rooms. (Focus group 5)

Parents' perceptions of transition activities

Finally, parents were also asked after the school transition what transition activities occurred and which were perceived as important. The results of the FEIT can be found in Table 5.

For all activities, 63.6% of parents reported them to have happened. They noted that two specific activities occurred the most: 'Meeting with Kindergarten teachers to plan transition/school start' (69.2%) and 'Meeting with child's teaching staff' (68.6%). Regarding the activities that did not occur but which parents would have wanted, 38.5% of the parents answered 'Telephone conversation with child's teacher' and 'A letter exchange with the staff of my child's future school', respectively. Activities that did not happen and that were not perceived as needed were 'An information event organized by the kindergarten about school transitions' (6.8%) and 'A house visit by my child's teacher' (10.6%). The results suggest parents wish for more transition activities, especially in communication with the new school. However, while parents were found to mostly agree on which transition activities they would like to occur, they seemed to disagree on whether home visits should happen.

Table 5. Parents' ratings of the FEIT ($n = 116$).

Activity	Yes, happened	Didn't happen, wish it had	Didn't happen, not needed either
1. Regular contact/communication with child's teacher	65.7%	34.3%	0%
2. Meeting with child's teaching staff	68.6%	30.4%	1.0%
3. Meeting with kindergarten teachers to plan transition/school start	69.2%	26.9%	3.8%
4. Meeting with school teachers to plan transition/school start	67.3%	27.9%	4.8%
5. A group visit of the future school	61.0%	37.0%	2.0%
6. An information event organized by the kindergarten about school transitions	65.0%	28.2%	6.8%
7. An information event organized by the future school about school transitions	64.4%	31.7%	3.8%
8. Telephone conversation with child's teacher	54.8%	38.5%	6.7%
9. A house visit by my child's teacher	43.3%	46.2%	10.6%
10. An orientation event organized by my child's future school	54.4%	37.9%	7.8%
11. A letter exchange with the staff of my child's kindergarten	63.5%	32.7%	3.8%
12. A letter exchange with the staff of my child's future school	57.7%	38.5%	3.8%
13. An open house day at my child's future school	58.7%	37.5%	3.8%
Average Total	63.6%	37.3%	4.7%

Triangulation of data

Points of convergence in the data suggest that educators and parents of migrant children value collaborations between institutions and with each other towards the school transition process, and that, while these collaborations do happen, they should happen more often. The focus group data further points to some difficulties with these collaborations, for instance, that they take time and that it can be challenging to work with parents. The educator survey data further suggests that they wish to show the child their classroom, and the parent data indicates that they wish for other forms of communication with educators, such as telephone meetings and letter exchanges.

Discussion

To our knowledge, this study presents the first attempt to investigate how educators and parents of migrant children perceive transition activities. The analysis of educators' views of transition activities revealed that different collaborations between educators and between educators and parents are implemented and perceived as necessary. The analysis of the educator survey suggests that many activities were not implemented, which educators perceived as important, indicating that educators may be ready to implement more transition activities than they already do because they understand their importance for migrant children. An analysis of educator surveys and focus group data suggests that they value transition activities and wish for more transition activities to be implemented in collaboration with other institutions, parents, and children, despite barriers such as the time needed for such collaborations. Moreover, analysis of parents' views of transition activities revealed their preferences for specific types of communication that did not occur, such as telephone and letter exchanges. As such, schools should encourage more communication between educators and parents of migrant children. Parents should be explicitly asked about what types of communication and collaboration they prefer in case they are more comfortable with some activities over others. For example, some families may not be comfortable with home visits as these activities can be perceived as invasive and particularly stigmatizing compared to other activities such as communication with the school through letter exchanges or telephone calls (McKnight et al. 2022). This is especially important considering the challenges faced by migrant families, especially newly arrived, such as the language barrier (Georgi 2024; Koehler and Schneider 2019; Passaretta and Skopek 2021). This is further in line with research about the role of migrant families' trust in schools which is dependent on potential feelings of being discriminated against by the school (Prokic 2024; Schuster, Bormann, and Hein 2025). Parents of migrant families' preferences for specific types of communication should be investigated further.

These results underscore some of the assumptions of the Ecological and Dynamic Model of Transitions (Rimm-Kaufman and Pianta 2000) by showing the shared, perceived importance of communication between educators and parents during the school transition, specifically for migrant children. These results also align with studies about school transition activities with non-migrant children, which found that educators and parents value communication and would like more to happen (LoCasale-Crouch et al. 2008; Schulting, Malone, and Dodge 2005). For instance, the results of the present study

corroborate work by Hopps (2014) in which preschool and school educators of native children self-report that communication between both institutions does not occur often enough, yet is important for the transition experiences of children and their families. These results also align with those by La Paro, Kraft-Sayre, and Pianta (2003) who found that teachers and parents of native children self-report transition activities as being necessary despite barriers, such as insufficient resources, to their implementation.

In summary, considering the struggles faced by migrant families, such as the language barrier, the findings of this initial research on transition activities suggest that the perspectives of educators and parents of migrant children need to be considered. They should be asked which transition activities they wish to see happen to facilitate a smoother transition to school for migrant children.

Strengths

A notable strength of this study is that it is the first to investigate transition activities specifically for migrant children in Germany, the OECD's second-largest immigrant-receiving country after the United States (OECD 2024). Various sources of information were investigated, namely, educators and parents, using various methods, including surveys and focus groups. In addition, in the surveys, participants were asked to rate which activities were implemented and how important these activities were to them. The results underline the need to understand the different perspectives of key stakeholders of school transitions and the activities needed to support migrant children during this significant life event. This study also highlights the benefit of working with an international NGO, the IRC. The collaboration between an academic institution, namely the Freie Universität Berlin, Germany, and the IRC provided insight into community-based and participatory research, which could serve as a blueprint for future collaborative research.

Limitations

Limitations of this study include the fact that different surveys were administered to educators and parents, rather than the same one, which could have been administered before and after the school transition to allow for comparisons. Moreover, it would have been informative to compare these data with the data from non-migrant parents to see whether transition activities are valued more by educators and parents of migrant children. Finally, children were not included in the current study. Future research could investigate children's perception of transition activities to understand which activities they perceived as important, such as having a school open-day event. In sum, while the present research, to our knowledge, is the first to examine how educators and parents of migrant children perceive transition activities, additional research is needed to allow for more in-depth insights into migrant families' experiences to understand how they can best be supported.

Implications and future directions

This study addresses a crucial gap in research on work with migrant children and their families as they transition between schools within the German system. Future efforts to support the transition to school should seek to focus more on teaching about transition

activities, for example by teaching about the long-term effects of specific activities such as exchanging information between schools about migrant children. The data from the present study underline the perceived importance of specific transition activities, especially communication, according to educators and parents of migrant children. These data can be referred to by institutions working with migrant children about to transition from kindergarten into primary school, as they provide evidence of educators' and parents' wishes for transition activities to occur. Such information could contribute towards the increasingly important field of research on teacher competencies working with heterogeneous classrooms (e.g., Dzerviniks et al. 2024). Schools should also consider this information when planning and developing policies around school transition activities specifically for migrant children. For instance, schools should make it routine to enquire among migrant families about which transition activities they perceive as beneficial. Moreover, because educators stressed the importance of transition activities while parents stressed the importance of specific activities, these preliminary results suggest that more communication is needed between teachers and parents to ensure that appropriate transition activities are implemented, which are desired by all involved.

The data also serves as a basis for future research on transition activities with migrant children. Future work could benefit from researching exactly which transition activities are perceived as useful after the school transition by not only educators and parents but also children themselves by, for instance, looking at which activities are associated with which outcomes such as grades, social skills, and adaptive behaviors at the end of the first school year. To this end, future research should also investigate specific participant characteristics in more depth, such as how long migrant families have been in Germany or whether educators have previously received specific, relevant training. Such information could also inform schools which specific activities help migrant children navigate the transition to school. Yet, more targeted research is needed to understand whether the school transition process is associated with stressful experiences of migrant children and their families. To understand this further, interviews or focus group discussions could be carried out with parents of migrant children before and after the school transition to allow them to freely express themselves and understand their perceptions of school transition activities in more depth.

Moreover, the timing of the data collection after the school transition is important so that parents can adequately answer the questions based on their transition experience. If prompted before the school transition, the answer options on the FEIT survey would lack validity. Regardless of the measures used, a design that measures expectations before and experiences after school transition from both perspectives (educators and parents) would undoubtedly be advantageous.

It is hoped that the results of this research draw attention to the importance of listening to the voices and perspectives of key actors in the transition process of migrant children and will contribute towards research seeking to support migrant children transitioning to school in Germany, empowering them to thrive.

Conclusion

Using mixed methods to investigate educators' and parents' views of transition activities, this preliminary investigation provides a first glimpse into which activities are

implemented in selected schools in Germany and are perceived as important, specifically for migrant children. The study results provide preliminary evidence that transition activities take place and are valued by educators and parents of migrant children transitioning from kindergarten to school in Germany, opening the door for more research on this neglected yet important topic.

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